# Don't Fall in Love with Your Monkey

## By Ari Handel

**ARI:** **(Pg 67-74)** Santiago is a wild animal. He does not want to be taken out of his cage. He keeps trying to hit my hand when I reach for him. He's big, and he's fast, and he's nimble. And I'm slow, in bulky clothing, and I'm starting to get hot. The monkeys in the room can sense that there's a conflict going on. They're starting to hoot and holler and screech.

Finally, I get one hand around Santiago's bicep, and [he] does exactly what you would do if some blue ogre reached into your house and grabbed you by the arm. He bites me as hard as he possibly can right here in the soft part of my hand. And it hurts. It really hurts. Every nerve in my hand is screaming, ***Drop the monkey.*** Instead, I reach my other hand in, grab his other bicep, and pull his arms behind his back. I stick him into his monkey chair and bring him down to the lab.

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## INTRODUCTION

*The U.S. uses about 70,000 monkeys per year in studies of the brain. But controversy over animal research goes back a long way: In one corner, the world of biomedical research insists animals are crucial in developing new treatments and that their pain is properly overseen and mitigated. In the other, animal rights activists say lab animals suffer and die needlessly, and that humans have no moral or ethical right to use other species in this way.*

*Did you know that the United Nations considers more than 15 days of solitary confinement in humans to be torture? But research monkeys often get a lifetime of solitary confinement in a 2.5 square foot cage. To cope, some monkeys pace in circles. Others rock or bounce for hours. A few self-stimulate by sticking their fingers into their eyes. Except for the monkeys in one Harvard University study where researchers have sewed baby macaques' eyelids shut to investigate how visual deprivation affects brain development.*

*In Don't Fall in Love with Your Monkey by Ari Handel, one researcher witnesses firsthand the psychological trauma of his research monkey, Santiago; and how easy it is to break the spirit of an animal in the name of research.*

**ARI:** Down in the lab, Santiago is now the one who is frightened. He is quaking, he is shivering in his chair. So, I take a bottle, and I fill it with juice -- Hawaiian punch. I can see his little mouth around the edge of the bottle, the juice is dripping down his chin, and he is

so cute. I see this look in his eyes, and it is joy.

When neurobiologists want to study the human mind, they look at the brains of monkeys. And I wanted to ask complex questions about mental functioning, and that meant that Santiago had to learn to play a video game. So I put him in a room facing a giant screen with a tube connected to his mouth that contained juice. I would go into the next room, where I had could control all these lights that would flash on that screen. Santiago's job was to look at the lights in the right order and with the right timing. If he did it right, he would get juice.

Now, this was not a very complicated game, but it was hard to teach Santiago how to play. I could not just tell him how. We had to invent our own language. I would watch Santiago's eye movements. If they were drifting slowly, that meant he was very frustrated, but if they were shimmering very fast, that meant he was excited. So I would watch his eyes and adjust the difficulty of the task accordingly, to cajole him forward or to calm him down. Slowly and surely, we learned together.

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And when we did, Santiago got very, very happy. He was like a gambler who had just cracked the code of the blackjack tables, because now he could get juice, juice, juice, as much as he wanted, and he would sit in that room, and play that game all day long. And he would drink tremendous volumes of juice; and that made me happy too, because I could lower a probe into Santiago's brain.

I would listen to the activity of individual neurons while he performed this task. And what I found was that there were neurons in Santiago's brain that would become activated every time he made an eye movement. But the thing that was cool, so cool, so cool it was mind-blowing, was that these neurons did not get activated just when he made a movement; they got activated as soon as I gave him enough information that he could choose which eye movement to make. Listening to these neurons, I could predict in advance what he was going to do before he did it. I was eavesdropping on him while he was making a decision. I was reading my monkey's mind.

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Santiago would get juice, and I would get data out of his brain, and we would do this for days and days and days. And then something happened. I went upstairs to get Santiago, and he tried to bite me. And when I brought him downstairs to the game room, he would not work, he just banged and banged and aborted every trial. ***Bang, bang, bang!***

I couldn't figure it out at first, and then it slowly dawned on me that Santiago must have figured out sometime during the night that I was not bringing him down to that room so that he could play games, so that he could have fun. I was bringing him down there for ***my*** benefit and he didn't want to do it anymore. I had a monkey who was on strike.

So . . . I turned off the water in Santiago's cage. He's only going to get ***enough*** water, but anything extra, he's going to have to earn. Every night I would give Santiago his little supplement of water, and he would drink it right down and then he would have nothing. I [was] filled with guilt over what I was doing to him. But when I put him in that booth and he still wouldn't

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work, that guilt turned to anger. Whose fault was it really that Santiago was not drinking? Whose fault was it that I felt guilty every day? It was Santiago's fault. He was sitting with the juice tube in his mouth, there was a game he knew how to play, and he wasn't playing. And I would get so angry with him sometimes, I would pull on his little monkey ear and he would go "EEEH." And then the anger would turn back to guilt.

This went on day after day after day after day. And I got so frustrated that eventually, I walked into the room and said, "I know you're thirsty. I'll show you how thirsty you are." I poured myself a huge glass of Hawaiian punch. I made eye contact with Santiago. And I drank that juice down, taunting him. And he just looked at me.

I was engaged in a battle of will with an animal whose brain was the size of my fist, and I was losing. I was supposed to be training him, and he was training me to get guilty, get angry, cross the line, get guilty again. No more. I was going to be hard. I was going to be serious.

When it was treat time, I went up to the room, and

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every monkey got treats: cucumbers and apples and grapes. But not Santiago. For Santiago, it was cashews and peanuts and crackers. Eventually there came a day, after months and months of suffering, I walked up to the monkey cage and Santiago just did this *[extends one arm]*. And when I took his hand in my hand, Santiago did this *[places his other arm behind his back]*. And I grabbed him, and I brought him downstairs to work. And he started to play the game. But he didn't play with the exceptional enthusiasm he had played it with before. He wasn't like, ***Wow, this is the greatest thing.*** He played the game like a factory worker on an assembly line ***whish, whish, whish.***

That should have been a good day for me. I was getting back to the science now. I would get my data, Santiago would get his juice. The suffering for us was over. But it wasn't a good day, because I had gotten to know Santiago. And now ***that*** Santiago wasn't there. I was sitting with just another monkey with a broken will. And I was the one who had broken it. The mystique of being a scientist -- of finding out all this stuff about the mind -- just didn't seem so magical anymore.

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There were other monkeys. I didn't need to be told not to fall in love with them. Instinctively, I held myself aloof from them, and because of that, I had no mercy on them. And when they went on strike, when they got upset and it was time to break them, I broke them like that *[snaps fingers]*. But I also didn't go up to the monkey room anymore. I didn't want to see those monkeys while they were still a little bit wild. I didn't want to be reminded of what I was going to do to that part of them.

It took me eight years, but I got all the data I needed, piece by piece by piece. And I got my Ph.D. And then I quit. My thesis is 364 pages long and s filled with facts and data and graphs and theories. But the most significant page for me is the first one, which says simply: ***"Dedicated to the memory of Santiago."***

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author:  Ari Handel***
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## AWARD HISTORY

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****Source information for the introduction was compiled from these 4 sources:***

1. ***https://www.vox.com/future-perfect/23795087/animal-experiments-primates-mental-health-effective***
2. ***https://www.peta.org/blog/new-study-confirms-murray-experiments-worthless/***
3. ***https://www.science.org/content/article/supply-monkeys-research-crisis-point-u-s-government-report-concludes***
4. ***https://www.thequardian.com/world/2022/may/31/primates-monkeys-scientific-experiments-peta-stop-testing***

***Find out more about animal research here:***

***Normalizing the Unthinkable:  The Ethics of Using Animals in Research***
***https://r.jordan.im/download/ethics/Normalising-the-Unthinkable-Report.pdf***

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